Challenge Stigma | Find Peace

FrontlineFolks | Guide #43

Underemployed, Overqualified, and Bored (or Overwhelmed)

A Field Guide for Frontline Folks and Their Families

Field notes for being too much for your job, or not enough, and all the frustration in between.

By Michael Jenkins, MS, MSW, LCSW
Never Forgotten Services, PLLC

Disclaimer

This guide is for general education only.

It is not:

- Therapy
- Medical care
- A crisis service
- Individualized advice

Reading this guide does not create a therapist–client relationship with the author or with Never Forgotten Services, PLLC.

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself or someone else, call 988 in the United States, go to your nearest emergency room, or contact your local emergency services.

If you want mental health treatment, please contact a licensed provider in your state or call the number on the back of your insurance card.

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1. What Is Happening

You have a decade of specialized expertise, and you're doing work a new hire could handle in a week. Or you landed in a role that expects you to out-perform immediately but your skills don't map cleanly. Either way, the fit is wrong. Underemployment is subtle but corrosive: you're watching the clock, resenting the work, feeling like your capability is wasted, and gradually losing the motivation that made you excellent at your former role. Overqualification doesn't just feel bad—it creates resentment, cynicism, and withdrawal from the very work you're being paid to do.

Common signs

- Boredom and disengagement: You've mastered the work in weeks. Now you're just filling time.
- Resentment toward leadership: They're not utilizing your skills. They don't see your capability.
- Status tension: You used to lead. Now you're equivalent to someone 20 years your junior.
- Cynicism: 'This place doesn't know what it's doing. These people have no idea.'
- Coasting vs. performance: You could do more but why bother? There's no incentive.
- Imposter syndrome (overwhelmed version): New role demands things your former skills don't transfer to.
- Skills mismatch: Your expertise doesn't map to the new context, so you're mediocre where you were excellent.
- Motivation collapse: You can't find a reason to care about work that doesn't challenge you.

> **This is a fit problem, not a character problem:**
> Underemployment and skills mismatch are structural. Your capability is real. The context isn't using it.

2. Why It Escalates

Your nervous system learned 'this is what high performance feels like'—challenge, urgency, high stakes, rapid decisions. The new role has none of that. Your brain gets less dopamine from under-stimulating work. You feel sluggish, resentful, and detached. Add status loss (you led before, now you follow), skills irrelevance (your expertise doesn't transfer), and a team that doesn't understand your background, and you get demotivation. The overwhelmed version is inverse: a new role that expects civilian-world competency you haven't yet built, which creates imposter syndrome where you used to be excellent.

Common amplifiers

- Under-stimulation deepening: The longer you're underemployed, the harder it is to motivate yourself for anything.
- Resentment escalating: You watch less qualified people being challenged while you're held back.
- Performance deteriorating: Boredom turns into visible coasting, which damages your reputation.
- Skills atrophy: High-level skills need use. Underemployment means you're losing the edge you came with.
- Status conflict with peers: Your former-role status bleeds into civilian interactions as condescension.
- Overwhelm compounding (other version): You're struggling in a role designed for someone with civilian experience you don't have.
- Shame entering: You were excellent. Now you're mediocre. Nobody says it but you feel it.

> *Why this works: reducing total load and increasing predictability lowers baseline arousal and improves regulation.*

3. What To Do This Week

You can address underemployment actively—either by changing the role, negotiating expanded responsibility, or using the job as runway while building toward something that fits.

1. Be honest about the mismatch: 'This role isn't using my capability' OR 'This role expects skills I haven't built yet.' Name it without judgment.
2. Talk to your supervisor about expanded scope: 'I've mastered my current responsibilities. I'd like to take on X. What's possible?' Most supervisors want engaged people.
3. Identify what skills do transfer: Even if specialty doesn't translate, leadership, project management, pressure performance, and teamwork are universally valuable.

4. Build skills to close the gap (overwhelmed version): If you're underprepared, identify specifically what you need and build it. Ask for training, mentorship, or timeline relief.
5. Decide: stay and adapt, or change: You can negotiate new scope, seek internal transfer, or start planning an exit. Staying resentful isn't a strategy.
6. Use downtime strategically: If you're underemployed, use the slack time for learning, building, networking—don't waste it on resentment.
7. Find stimulation outside work temporarily: While navigating the transition, find stimulation through education, volunteer work, or side projects.
8. Set a decision timeline: 'I'll try to change my scope for 90 days. If nothing improves, I'll make a different plan.' Reduces the helplessness of indefinite drift.
9. Stop comparing to former-role performance: That context had specific scaffolding. This context is different. You're not failing, you're adapting.

> Field rule: set the bar low enough to do it even on your worst day.

4. For Partners and Team

Stress communication should be clear, brief, and repeatable. Predictable routines protect relationships.

- Use concrete language: 'I'm underemployed and it's affecting my motivation. I need either more challenge or a plan to move.'
- Name what you need: 'I need you to understand that I have skills not being used here, and it's making it hard to stay engaged.'
- Be transparent about the overwhelm: 'I was excellent in my former role. I'm struggling here. I need support.'
- Avoid resentment projection: Your frustration is about the fit, not about individual coworkers who don't have your background.

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5. When To Get More Help

Self-guided tools are a start. Escalate care when symptoms persist, spread, or begin harming safety and function.

- Chronic underemployment has lasted 6+ months and your performance is visibly suffering.
- Resentment is affecting your relationships at work or home.
- You're stuck in a role that doesn't fit and can't identify a path out.
- Skills mismatch is creating shame and avoidance that's spreading beyond work.

- Career counseling can help identify transferable skills and map realistic pathways to better-fit roles.

6. 7-Day Field Drill

Use the worksheet every day for one week. Track trigger, body signal, and reset action. Keep what works and remove what does not.

> **Daily drill:**
> 1) Name the trigger.
> 2) Name the first body signal.
> 3) Run one reset action.
> 4) Log response quality.

Worksheet 1: Worksheet: Underemployed, Overqualified, and Bored (or Overwhelmed)

Use this to track the pattern in this chapter and build a practical response you can repeat under load.

Where did this pattern show up this week?

List specific moments at work, at home, and in transition.

What did it cost you when it took over?

Name impact on body, mood, decisions, and relationships.

What two actions will you run for the next 7 days?

Choose actions small enough to use on hard days.

1. Trigger:

What activated the pattern?

2. Early body signal:

What did your body do first?

3. Reset action used:

What fast action lowered intensity?

4. Better next response:

What exact behavior will you use next time?

> Track this daily for one week, then tighten the plan around what actually worked.

Worksheet 2: Worksheet: Underemployed, Overqualified, and Bored (or Overwhelmed) - Partner/Team Check-In

Use this page for one short practical check-in each week.

What do others notice first when this pattern is active?

Capture observable behavior, not labels.

What support helps most and least?

List what helps and what escalates the issue.

What agreement will you both practice this week?

One clear action from each side.

1. Signal phrase:

What phrase means pause and reset?

2. Time-to-return commitment:

When will re-engagement happen?

3. Repair step:

What specific repair happens after a rupture?

> Keep check-ins short, specific, and repeatable.

Closing

You've seen and carried more than most people will ever know.

Blow ups and shutdowns are not proof that you're broken or that your relationship is doomed.

They are signs that your nervous system has been running in survival mode for a long time.

The fact that you picked up this guide and read it matters.

You are choosing to be intentional about how you show up for the people who matter to you.

That choice is a lot more powerful than having flawless days.

About the Author

Michael Jenkins, MS, MSW, LCSW

Founder, Never Forgotten Services, PLLC

Michael is a U.S. Army combat veteran and licensed clinical social worker who specializes in working with military, veterans, and first responders—our frontline folks. After leaving the military, he spent years fighting his own demons and trying to figure out why he could hold it together on the job but feel completely wrecked at home. The turning point was realizing he wasn't the only one living that split life—and that nobody should have to feel that alone, confused, or broken by what the job asks of them.

Since then, his work has focused on trauma, the impact of high-stress jobs on home life, and helping families make sense of what the job brings home. He uses plain language, zero shame, and a "you're not crazy, this actually makes sense" approach to help frontline folks and their families understand what's happening in their nervous systems and learn how to move through the chaos together.